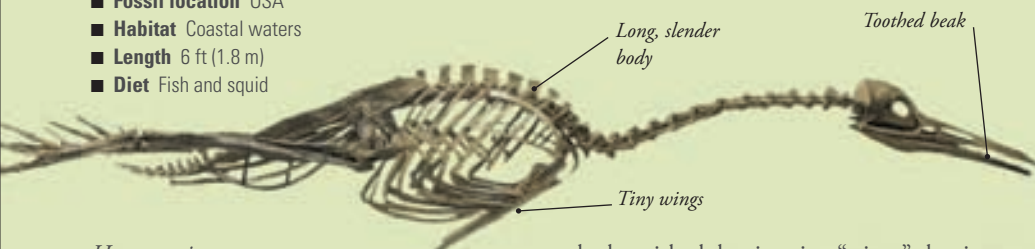


# Hesperornis

hess-per-ORE-niss

- **When** 75 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Coastal waters
- **Length** 6 ft (1.8 m)
- **Diet** Fish and squid



*Hesperornis* was an enormous seabird that had lost the power of flight but become an expert diver. It used its huge feet to push itself through the water as it chased squid and fish, which it caught in a toothed beak. The bones of its hands and forearms

had vanished, leaving tiny “wings” that it likely used for steering in water. Like all birds, *Hesperornis* nested on land, but it was probably unable to walk and had to push itself along on its belly.



# Iberomesornis

I-beh-ro-may-SORE-niss

- **When** 135–120 million years ago (Early Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Spain
- **Habitat** Woodlands of western Europe
- **Length** 8 in (20 cm)
- **Diet** Probably insects

*Iberomesornis* was about the size of a finch. It had a stumpy tail and powerful chest muscles, indicating it was a good flyer, and its curved foot claws suggest it perched on trees. But it had features similar to a dinosaur, too, including large claws on its wings.



# Ichthyornis

ICK-thee-OR-niss

- **When** 90–75 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Seashores
- **Length** 2 ft (0.6 m)
- **Diet** Fish



*Ichthyornis* (“fish bird”) was a seabird, similar in size and weight to a modern seagull, but its head and beak were much larger. It had a large, keeled breastbone, showing it had powerful breast muscles and was a strong flyer. However, its jaws were packed with small, curved

# Vegavis

VAY-gah-viss

- **When** 65 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Antarctica
- **Habitat** Coast of Antarctica
- **Length** 2 ft (0.6 m)
- **Diet** Water plants

Fossils of *Vegavis*, a relative of ducks and geese, were found in Antarctica in 1992. The discovery was important because it showed that some of today’s bird families had already evolved during the age of dinosaurs. *Vegavis* lived in Antarctica when its climate was much less cold than today.

